i know i'm a mess she don't wanna clean up

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53110939.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Grief/Mourning, Established Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Sad and Sweet, Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, just 2500 words of adora freaking out and catra and finn taking care of her, Hurt/Comfort, adora's family taking care of her

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by petty_labelle

Summary

adora attempts to find the perfect way to honor her former foster mother, light hope's, memory. turns out, it's harder than she thought but finn and catra are there for her.

or chapter 11, "mine", of hunger hurts but it's adora turn

Notes

hhsw returns! for an extremely short period!

See the end of the work for more notes

“Maybe I could make her ashes into a vase or-or a door stopper or something?” Adora says but honestly she hasn't entirely been listening to herself as she rattled off ideas for the past… actually who knows how long it's been. While she's usually hyper aware of time, the last few days have somehow blended into one long lump of scattered, racing thoughts and a heaviness in her chest that she's not sure she'll ever get rid of again. There's a fear – one that Adora knows doesn't particularly make sense – that everyone's watching and everything she does in these next few days will either make or break the image everyone has of her.

“She’d love that,” Adora keeps mumbling. “Still getting to be put to work.”

Her laptop is open and so is Catra's iPad, both on the floor where Adora's seated among the meager amount of photos she has of Hope. A slightly blurry old Polaroid of Hope sitting at the dinner table and staring straight into the camera, unblinking and lips set in a line. A faded 5’ by 7’ of her and Adora just kinda standing in each other’s general direction after Adora’s graduation. A couple more shots from seemingly random days – Hope in the yard, Hope next to her truck, no particular indicators of time. What was happening for her that day? Was it memorable? Remarkable? Some big day that she just never told Adora about-

Oh, there's also about 2 dozen scribbled-on post-it notes littered around but those aren't important anymore, the last lingering remains of a 2 am spitball session that went nowhere and only succeeded in making Catra look at Adora like she'd lost touch with reality.

Shit. Catra.

“Hmm?” her voice hums quietly.

Adora glances up and Catra's stretched across their bed, lounging near the edge on her belly so she can keep an eye on her

girlfriend. Catra gives her a soft smile before asking gently, “What's up, baby?”

Did Adora think that or say it out loud? Regardless, now Catra's looking at her, face all worry and love and pity, and Adora kinda hates it. Her therapist says she should lean into gratitude.

Right now, she'd be grateful if the person she loves most on Etheria doesn't realize that Adora forgot she was in the room.

Adora buries her face back into the search results on screen #1, scrambling for something to say that won't alarm Catra any more.

“I could make a headstone,” she reads next. The words rewind in her head and Adora hears a dry laugh leap out of her throat. “A headstone? Yeah, on it, I could write ‘didn’t want to bother anyone.’ I should put that in her obituary actually. ‘Oh, what did she die of? SHE DIDN’T WANT ANYONE TO WORRY ABOUT HER!’” Adora’s voice pierces through their typically-at least somewhat-quiet home and she winces in shame. “I’m sorry.”

“No, you’re *grieving,”* Catra corrects her. “That’s fine.”

She doesn't reach out to comfort Adora. Not anymore. Not after she lifted a hand in a hug and Adora flinched so badly they both froze.

Adora’s body was just in some sort of hyper on guard state and she tensed up for a fight. Catra’s given her a wide berth since then, at least when it comes to sudden touches. Truthfully, Adora misses the way that Catra would usually grab her hand or lean into her body, just letting Adora know that she’s there. Catra’s still there.

But it’s okay not to have that right now. Adora doesn’t really deserve to be comforted anyway.

There’s a soft knock on the door and Adora immediately leaps up from where she’d just been crumbled on the floor and begins rearranging the index cards she’d laid out on the bed with

memorial ideas. Those are probably a bit too much for Finny to see but it's a lot better than them having to witness Adora falling apart. No matter how many times Catra reminds Adora of how she was after Weaver died and how Finn was there for all of it, Adora can't make them go through that again. They're so young, they don't need more loss in their life. Adora only wants to bring them safety and security and a normal childhood.

Catra gives her an odd look as she watches Adora move the cards around aimlessly again. "Come on in, bud."

Adora hadn't realized it had gotten so late – Finn's already in their pjs, a bright red fleece onesie that looks like it's built for naps. It even had a hood and Catra had tried in vain to find one in an adult size so she didn't have to endure this jealousy. She lived for a comfy statement item.

Finn had been extra well-behaved lately, and now they were putting themselves to bed without a 15-minute fight? She had the best kid ever.

Seeing as how Catra was lounging on the part of the bed *not* taken up with index cards, a perfect position for a surprise pouncing, Adora had expected Finn to launch an attack.

Instead, Finn slowly walks up to her like maybe they got the memo about no sudden movements too and hands Adora a folded piece of red cardboard paper.

"Cat said I should be encouraging," they explain.

It's a card, Adora realizes. Finn's cut out and pasted some white and black shapes and it looks kinda like a modern art exhibit that she wouldn't understand but Catra would pretend to get. Inside, in Finn's blocky handwriting, there's 'it's okay to be sad.' On the other side, there's an Adora made of circles and squares and yellow and white paper. Next to her is an orange and yellow paper block person about half her height.

Adora can feel the tears well up but the breath she takes to steady them somehow blows away her last shred of dignity. She holds the card far from her body so it doesn't get wet.

"Thank you," she blubbers.

She can hear Finn whisper to Catra, "It's not that good."

"It's perfect," Adora argues. In a heartbeat, she's kneeling down and pulling them into a hug and try as she might to keep it as quiet as humanly possible, she's still sure that Catra hears her whisper, "I'll love you forever."

Finn, of course, doesn't bother asking why she'd be shy enough to try to keep that last sentence between them.

"It's okay. I won't blame you if you die," in that incisive way they're able to cut through her bullshit without even trying.

Adora wipes her eyes as she pulls back, waiting on her knees so she can look into Finn's amazing, wonderful, glorious little face. Her mouth opens to argue but really there's nothing to combat that with. Nothing that Adora would be willing to say out loud, not to Finn, who can't understand the nuances of the swirl of feelings that have combined themselves in her chest into a giant rubber band ball that can't be untangled. And not in front of Catra, who is old enough and smart enough to tear apart any argument Adora has in an attempt to make her feel better.

Adora doesn't particularly *want* to feel better. She doesn't deserve it. And anyway, it's too soon. There's very likely some etiquette on when you're allowed to feel joy again after losing a parental figure.

But Finn doesn't let it go. "Do you blame Hope for dying?"

"No," Adora answers immediately, frowning so they know she's serious. "Of course not." Yes, maybe a little. It's…complicated.

“Do you blame yourself for Hope dying?” Finn asks because they’re a child genius and while she’s usually proud of that, that isn’t the level of intuition that she’s prepared for right now.

Because, yes, of course Adora does. She’s capable and dependable and she could have done something if Hope bothered to tell *one other person* what the fuck was going on.

She fell, she claimed. Just a fall, nothing spectacular. It was barely a blip on their quarterly call. Imagine Adora’s surprise when a hospital called her 10 months later to ask her consent to pursue an alternative line of treatment now that Hope was slipping in and out of being responsive. Bless Catra who was calm and rational enough to book Adora a flight out the next day, while Adora was still scrambling to understand how a fall had escalated so badly.

A *fall.* What a laugh. Hope had been light-headed from *chemo,* which she’d been secretly undergoing for months. She’d been lying to everyone — her coworkers had no idea what was going on, her doctors thought she’d told everyone and was making medical decisions with her family’s input. Even Mara had been kept in the dark and Adora just knew she must have had access to some leading medical specialist halfway around the world, a person who was testing cell regeneration by giving dolphins LSD or something, and a legion of healers and shamans and miracle workers.

“No, Finny,” Adora finally answers because the kid had a will of steel and would wait around all day until they were acknowledged.

“Cub? Go turn off all the lights and lower all the curtains for me, please?”

Finn nods solemnly as if Catra’s just asked them to take on the most important task in the household. In a flash, tiny arms are tossed around Adora’s neck, claws scratching along her upper back in an attempt to comfort her.

“I’ll let you eat all the ice cream, okay?” Finn whispers. “It makes Cat fart anyway.”

“Dude!” Catra objects but they’ve already dashed off and shut the door behind themself, yelling good night.

Lights off usually means sleep time for Finn and some quiet tv time for the adults. So Adora begins dutifully packing her mess, even though she’s no fucking closer to choosing the perfect way to honor Hope.

At the top of her stack of cards and notes and devices are the photos. Hope. In color, in black and white, in sepia. Never smiling. Always so afraid the future and stuck in the fucking past.

Adora asks no one in particular, her words coming out against her own will. “I’m not going to be like that, am I?”

“Hmm?” Catra is still so painfully tender like Adora’s made of paper.

“Stubborn and secretive and…like her?”

“I mean, probably.”

Adora’s eyes shoot up to her so fast the pile of junk almost topples out of her arms. Catra merely shrugs and it’s the most normal that she’s treated Adora since this all happened. Thank Gods.

“You stubbed your toe last week and refused to admit you were limping for two whole days,” Catra reminded her.

“I didn’t want you to worry,” Adora argues. And then she thinks of the fake tombstone and the sound that comes out of her is somewhere between a laugh and a sob and honestly, a twisted gut-wrenching parody of either because Adora doesn’t deserve to be laughing and she certainly doesn’t deserve to be crying, not when she wasn’t there when Hope needed her the most.

“Adora,” Catra says, voice firm and clear. “Look at me.” She hadn’t realized she wasn’t and wasn’t particularly sure when she decided to lie down but somehow Adora finds the will to raise her head from the floor to glance up. “If you think me or Finn or, Gods forbid, Glimmer Fucking Moon are gonna let you ever suffer in silence, trying to pull some self-sacrificing tough guy act, you’re an idiot.”

That was true. Between the three of them, they’d launch a full-scale national investigation if Adora caught so much as a fever.

“Can you change the way you’re wired overnight? Nope. You’re incredibly lucky though to have surrounded yourself with people who show their love by being absolutely bonkers and never leaving you alone.”

“Can you just be touching me now please?” Adora begs.

“Please finally lie down and I will.”

Somehow, a nod feels like too much, like her head is too heavy. But Adora finds the strength to lift her giant head, strip down to this faded black tanktop she’s been wearing for way too long and her underwear and dives under the covers. Catra is very likely hinting that she should bathe but Adora doesn’t need to be a hero today.

By the time Catra’s changed into her bedclothes, Adora’s moved from the ‘how’s on what the hell she’s supposed to be doing’ to the ‘why’s’, which is a scary road that she’s so far only stumbled onto in the middle of the night and is best left there.

But again, she finds words tumbling out, unhinged, “I don’t even know if I should be grieving her,” Adora says, like she and Catra are in a fight for some reason. “Things were so complicated between us.”

So far, Catra has yet to respond to any change in Adora’s tone by matching her where she’s at and it’s so patient and annoying. “I

hated Weaver and I still couldn't get out of bed for *days,"* Catra casually reassures Adora.

The other side of the sheets lift up and Catra slides in, smelling like clean clothes and home. The second her hands touch the bare skin of Adora's shoulder, Catra yelps as she ends up on her back, a face pressed to her chest. Adora can't feel Catra's fur through her shirt, which is awful, but she's afraid to move and lose even another moment together.

Barely moving her lips away from where she's nuzzled into Catra's chest, she mumbles freely, "My parents died. Hope died. I just… how do we do this knowing everyone's gonna eventually leave us?"

"Do what?"

"Life!" Adora responds. The word gets lost a little as she chokes on it.

For a while, she just listens to Catra's breath, feeling so grateful to hear it.

"I'm gonna live forever," Catra says eventually.

"Like Fame?"

"There's so many things I don't want to miss sharing with you," Catra tries instead.

"Right," Adora breathes out. Her arms tighten as her chest uncoils slightly.

Right. She pulls Catra impossibly close. They'd nearly lost each other before, to their own fears and unfounded anxieties. Adora didn't want to waste more moments like that. Didn't want to be so obsessed with guarding against the possibility of bad that she couldn't let good in.

“Mara,” Adora says finally. “I should ask Mara what she thinks for the memorial stuff. Honestly, I could probably ask her to handle more of this part since I did a lot of the doctor stuff.”

“That sounds like a fair trade,” Catra replies in the patient yet bored tone of a person who’s definitely heard this idea, if not produced it themselves outright. Adora wonders if Catra had suggested that a bunch of times already. She was having a little trouble remembering stuff, which Catra had assured her was perfectly normal during a traumatic time and Adora still thought she could beat it if she tried hard enough.

She sighs into Catra. “I need to chill a bit.”

Catra’s left hand drifts up Adora’s back and tangles into her hair. Claws go to her scalp and begin to lightly massage, just as a steady purr rumbles to life under Adora’s ear.

“That sounds nice. You’ll stay with me?” Catra whispers, already pulling the blanket up higher around Adora’s shoulder.

Adora remembers the first time Catra asked that, when she wasn’t sure if it was for today or forever. But she responds the same, “Of course,” closing her eyes and wishing for today and as many tomorrows as possible.

End Notes

many thanks to milli for betaing in the middle of the night.

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